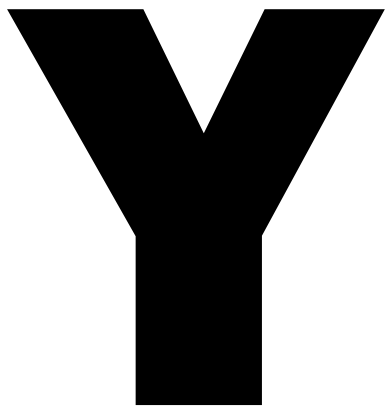




32 | YOU CAN'T CALL them bulls or bears, but they sure are the “queens” of the stock market. They are women who carved out novel careers that began as investment managers, analysts, or just marketing grunts. They worked up to the top in a male-dominated world to become big-time fund managers, head broking agencies, or even a stock exchange board.

About time, too: the National Stock Exchange, which has 10 million registered investors, said in

August that one in five investors is a woman. According to Morningstar India, an investment research firm, the number of women fund managers has grown from 18 in 2017, the year from which Morningstar began keeping records, to 42 in 2023. The number may be small (about 9% of the 473 fund managers in the industry), but these women managed ₹6.66 lakh crore of assets as of January 2024.

Deena Mehta, the 63-year-old Managing Director of Asit C Mehta Investment Intermediates, says, “The irony is Laxmi [the Hindu goddess of wealth, fortune and prosperity] and Saraswati [the goddess of knowledge, music, arts, wisdom and learning] are women. It’s time to bust the myth that only men can handle financial planning or investment management.”

Mehta and others such as Amisha Vora, Priti Rathi Gupta, Devina Mehra, Lakshmi Iyer, and Radhika Gupta are demolishing myths left and right despite the usual hurdles that women face: looking after the children and managing the home front.

ONE AT A TIME, PLEASE

Picture this: You are a stock trader glued to the screens in your office. Back home, your child skipped school because of a fever, but you know your wife is looking after him. Now picture this: You, dear Mommy, are the one in front of the trading screens, your husband is in his office... and your child is in the care of your in-laws. Should you be calling home every 15 minutes?

No. That’s some focussed advice from Mehta, who got into the stock market business to escape a mundane finance job at a manufacturing blue chip and went on to become the first woman president of the BSE. She advises women to be clear about their priorities. “If you leave an unwell child with your mother-in-law, you should give 100% if you go to work. Being in the office and calling home every 15 minutes would not help.”

Lakshmi Iyer, CEO-Investment & Strategy at Kotak Alternate Asset Managers, admits that it can be difficult to avoid guilt when you have a little child waiting at home.

A RISING FORCE

The representation of women in the financial sector is rising steadily on both the investment management and investment sides



However, women money managers still account for under 10% of all money managers in the industry

Women fund managers managed assets worth ₹6.66 lakh crore as of January 2024, per Morningstar Direct



Things are better on the investor side, where women now constitute one in five investors, indicating their growing influence in finance

This is evident in the fact that women increasingly take charge of personal finances, with 47% making independent decisions

